

# Clinical Dialogue Transcript — Addiction

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## THERAPIST (Turn 1)

Hi, thanks for coming in today. What's been going on for you lately?

## PATIENT (Turn 2)

Honestly, not much. My partner's been on my case about my drinking, but I think they're overreacting. I mean, I can handle it, I'm not some kind of alcoholic or anything.

## THERAPIST (Turn 3)

It sounds like there's been some tension with your partner about your drinking habits. Can you tell me more about what's been going on and how you've been feeling about their concerns? It's understandable that you might feel defensive or dismissive of their worries, but it's also possible that they're seeing something that you're not.

Also, I want to acknowledge that you said you're not an alcoholic, and that's a significant statement. Have you ever stopped to think about why you feel the need to say that, or what would happen if you did consider the possibility that your drinking might be a problem? Sometimes, our initial reactions can be a good indicator of what's really going on beneath the surface.

Let's explore this further. Can you describe a typical drinking scenario for you? How often do you drink, and how much do you usually have? And what do you think your partner is concerned about, specifically?

## PATIENT (Turn 4)

Look, I just think my partner is worrying too much, okay? I like to have a good time, I like to unwind after work, and a few drinks helps me do that. I don't see what the big deal is. And yeah, maybe I have had a few mornings where I didn't feel so great, but that's just part of it, right? I don't know why we have to analyze this so much.

### **THERAPIST (Turn 5)**

It can feel frustrating when someone is questioning our habits or behaviors, especially when we feel like we're just trying to relax and have a good time. It's understandable that you might feel like your partner is overreacting or being too controlling.

However, as someone who is here to support you, I want to gently point out that your partner's concerns might be coming from a place of care and love for you. It's possible that they've noticed some changes in your behavior or mood when you're drinking, and they're worried about how it might be affecting your well-being or your relationship.

I'm not here to judge you or tell you that you need to stop drinking entirely. But I do want to encourage you to consider your partner's perspective and to explore your own motivations and habits around drinking. It's possible that there are some underlying issues or stressors that you're trying to cope with through drinking, and addressing those might be a more effective way to manage your stress and anxiety in the long run.

You mentioned that you've had some mornings where you didn't feel so great after drinking. Can you tell me more about what that's like for you? How do you feel physically and emotionally on those mornings? And how do you think your drinking might be impacting your daily life, relationships, or overall well-being?

Also, I want to ask, have you ever found yourself drinking more than you intended to, or feeling like you need to drink in order to relax or have fun? These can be subtle signs that our drinking habits might be becoming a problem, and it's worth exploring them further.

### **PATIENT (Turn 6)**

I don't know, it's just...mornings are rough, okay? I feel shaky, my head is pounding, and I just want to go back to bed. But I have to get up and go to work, so I just kind of...push through it, I guess. And yeah, sometimes I do drink more than I meant to, but that's just because I'm having a good time, you know? It's not a big deal.

### **THERAPIST (Turn 7)**

It sounds like you're experiencing some physical symptoms that are commonly associated with hangovers, such as shakiness and headaches. And it's understandable that you'd want to just push through and get on with your day, especially when you have work or other responsibilities to attend to.

However, I want to gently suggest that it might be worth exploring the idea that these physical symptoms could be a sign that your body is trying to tell you something. When we're drinking to the point where we're experiencing hangovers, it can be a indication that we're putting a lot of stress on our bodies.

And I also want to explore this idea of "having a good time" and how that relates to your drinking. It's great that you enjoy socializing and having fun, but it's possible that your drinking is becoming a way to cope with stress, anxiety, or other emotions. When we use drinking as a way to manage our emotions, it can create a cycle where we feel like we need to drink in order to relax or have fun.

I'm not saying that you're not capable of having fun without drinking, or that you need to cut it out entirely. But I do think it's worth considering the idea that there might be other ways to manage your stress and emotions that don't involve drinking.

Can you tell me more about what you mean by "having a good time" when you're drinking? Is it the social aspect, the feeling of relaxation, or something else entirely? And are there other activities or hobbies that you enjoy that don't involve drinking?

Also, I want to ask, have you ever felt like you've lost control or done something while drinking that you later regretted? This can be a sign that our drinking is becoming a problem, and it's worth exploring further.

### **PATIENT (Turn 8)**

I just like letting loose, you know? It's like, when I'm drinking, I can just forget about all my worries and stress and just have fun. And yeah, sometimes I do things that I might regret later, but that's just part of it, right? It's not a big deal. I mean, who doesn't do stupid stuff when they're drinking?

### **THERAPIST (Turn 9)**

It sounds like you're using drinking as a way to temporarily escape from your stress and worries, and to feel more carefree and spontaneous. And it's true that many people do engage in behaviors while drinking that they might regret later.

However, I want to gently suggest that it's possible to have fun and let loose without drinking to the point where you're losing control or doing things you might regret. And it's also possible that your drinking is becoming a way to avoid dealing with your underlying stress and worries, rather than addressing them in a more constructive way.

I'm not here to judge you or tell you that you need to stop drinking entirely. But I do want to encourage you to think more critically about your relationship with drinking, and to consider whether it's truly serving you in the way that you want it to.

It's also worth exploring the idea that your drinking might be a coping mechanism for underlying issues or emotions that you're not fully addressing. For example, are you using drinking to manage anxiety, depression, or stress? Or are you drinking to try to fit in with certain social groups or to feel more confident?

I want to ask, what do you think would happen if you didn't drink for a while? Would you feel anxious, irritable, or restless? Or would you feel more in control, more confident, and more able to manage your stress and emotions in healthier ways?

Also, I want to talk about the regrets you mentioned. What kind of things have you done while drinking that you've later regretted? Have you ever hurt someone's feelings, damaged a relationship, or put yourself in a situation that could have had serious consequences? These are important questions to consider, because they can help us understand whether our drinking is truly serving us, or if it's causing more harm than good.

#### **PATIENT (Turn 10)**

Honestly, if I didn't drink for a while, I think I'd feel pretty anxious and restless. I'd probably have trouble sleeping and just feel on edge all the time. And as for the regrets, I don't know...I've said some stupid things to my partner, and we've gotten into fights about it. And there was one time I woke up in a hotel room with no memory of how I got there, which was pretty scary. But like I said, that's just part of it, right?

#### **THERAPIST (Turn 11)**

It sounds like you're experiencing some significant withdrawal symptoms when you're not drinking, such as anxiety, restlessness, and trouble sleeping. These symptoms can be uncomfortable and even distressing, and it's understandable that you might feel like you need to drink to manage them.

However, I want to suggest that these symptoms might be a sign that your body is dependent on alcohol to some extent. When we drink regularly, our bodies can adapt by changing the way they produce and regulate certain chemicals, such as serotonin and dopamine. This can lead to a situation where we feel like we need to drink in order to feel normal, because our bodies are used to the presence of alcohol.

Regarding the regrets you mentioned, it's clear that your drinking has had some negative consequences in your relationships and personal life. The fact that you've said things to your partner that you regret, and that you've gotten into fights about it, suggests that your drinking is causing some tension and conflict in your relationship. And the experience of waking up in a hotel room with no memory of how you got there is a serious red flag, as it suggests that you may be putting yourself in situations that could be harmful or even dangerous.

I want to emphasize that it's not just about "part of it" or "just having fun." Your drinking is having real consequences, and it's worth taking a closer look at why you're drinking and what you're trying to achieve through it.

I'd like to explore the idea of seeking some additional support and resources to help you manage your drinking and address any underlying issues that may be contributing to it. Would you be open to discussing some options for counseling or therapy, or perhaps looking into some local support groups for people who are struggling with similar issues?

### **PATIENT (Turn 12)**

I don't know...I'm not sure I need all that. I just need to get my drinking under control, you know? I don't want to have to go to some meeting or talk to a therapist all the time. Can't I just, like, cut back on my own or something?

### **THERAPIST (Turn 13)**

It can be intimidating to consider seeking outside help, and it's understandable that you might want to try to manage your drinking on your own.

However, I want to gently suggest that trying to cut back on your own might not be the most effective approach, especially if you've already tried to do so in the past and haven't been successful. The fact that you're experiencing withdrawal symptoms and having trouble managing your drinking suggests that it may be more than just a matter of willpower or self-control.

Additionally, seeking outside help can provide you with a safe and supportive environment to explore your relationship with drinking, identify underlying issues that may be contributing to your behavior, and develop strategies for managing your drinking in a healthy and sustainable way.

I'm not saying that you need to commit to long-term therapy or attend meetings forever. But even just a few sessions with a therapist or a brief period of attendance at a support group could provide you with the tools and support you need to get your drinking under control and improve your overall well-being.

It's also worth considering that seeking help is a sign of strength, not weakness. It takes courage to acknowledge that you need support and to take steps to address your challenges.

If you're still hesitant, I want to ask: what do you think is the worst that could happen if you seek outside help? And what do you think are the potential benefits of getting support?

Also, I want to offer you a compromise: we can work together to develop a plan for you to cut back on your drinking, and we can monitor your progress over time. If you're able to successfully manage your drinking on your own, then that's great. But if you find that you're struggling or that your drinking is still causing problems, then we can revisit the idea of seeking outside help. How does that sound?

#### **PATIENT (Turn 14)**

I guess that sounds okay. I just don't want to feel like I'm losing control or that I'm some kind of addict. But at the same time, I don't want to keep feeling like I'm stuck in this cycle of drinking and regretting it. Maybe it would be good to just talk to someone and see if they can help me figure some things out.

#### **THERAPIST (Turn 15)**

It's completely understandable that you wouldn't want to feel like you're losing control or that you're an addict. But seeking help is actually a sign of taking control of your life and your choices. It's a brave and proactive step to acknowledge that you need support and to take concrete actions to address your challenges.

And I think it's great that you're recognizing the cycle of drinking and regretting it. That's a really important insight, and it suggests that you're ready to make some changes.

Talking to someone can be a really helpful way to explore your feelings and behaviors, and to identify patterns and underlying issues that may be contributing to your drinking. It's a safe and non-judgmental space to discuss your concerns and to work through challenges.

I want to reassure you that I'm not here to label you or to make you feel like you're an addict. My goal is to support you in exploring your relationship with drinking, and to help you develop strategies for managing your behavior in a way that feels healthy and sustainable for you.

Let's start by setting some specific goals for what you'd like to achieve in terms of your drinking. What does "getting your drinking under control" mean to you? Is it about reducing the amount you drink, or the frequency, or something else entirely? What are some specific changes you'd like to make, and how will you know if you're successful?

Also, I want to ask: what do you think is the most challenging part of changing your drinking behavior? Is it the social pressure, the stress and anxiety, or something else? Let's explore this further and see if we can identify some strategies for overcoming these challenges.

### **PATIENT (Turn 16)**

I guess I'd like to be able to have just a few drinks and stop, without feeling like I need to keep going. And maybe not drink every day, just on weekends or special occasions. That sounds pretty normal, right? But it's hard, because when I start drinking, I just feel like I need to keep going, and it's hard to stop.

### **THERAPIST (Turn 17)**

It sounds like you're looking to develop a healthier relationship with drinking, where you can enjoy a few drinks without feeling like you need to overdo it. And that's a great goal! Being able to control your drinking and make choices that align with your values and goals is a key part of maintaining a healthy lifestyle.

It's interesting that you mention feeling like you need to keep going once you start drinking. This is a common phenomenon, and it's often referred to as the "abstinence-violation effect." Essentially, once you start drinking, your brain can get into a mode where it's hard to stop, because the initial drink has triggered a release of dopamine and other pleasure chemicals. This can create a self-reinforcing cycle, where you feel like you need to keep drinking to maintain the good feelings.

But the good news is that you can break this cycle by developing new habits and strategies for managing your drinking. One approach might be to set a specific goal for yourself, such as limiting your drinks to a certain number or only drinking on certain days of the week. You can also try to identify the triggers that tend to lead you to overdrink, and develop plans for avoiding or coping with those triggers.

For example, if you know that you tend to drink more when you're out with friends, you might try setting a limit for yourself before you go out, or finding ways to stay occupied and engaged that don't involve drinking. You could also try finding alternative ways to relax and have fun that don't involve drinking, such as exercise, hobbies, or spending time with friends and family.

It's also important to remember that it's okay to say no to drinks, or to stop drinking at any point if you feel like you've had enough. You don't have to feel like you need to keep going just because you've started drinking. And if you do find yourself struggling to control your drinking, there are many resources available to support you, from counseling and support groups to medication and other forms of treatment.

Let's work on developing a plan for you to achieve your goal of drinking in moderation. What do you think would be the most challenging part of this plan for you, and how can we work together to overcome those challenges?

### **PATIENT (Turn 18)**

I think the hardest part would be when I'm out with friends and they're all drinking. It's hard to say no when everyone around me is having a good time and drinking. I feel like I'll be missing out or that they'll think I'm boring if I don't drink.

### **THERAPIST (Turn 19)**

It can be really tough to say no to drinking when you're in a social situation and everyone around you is drinking. It's like you feel like you're being left out or that you'll be judged for not participating.

First of all, let me tell you that it's completely normal to feel this way. Many people struggle with the pressure to drink in social situations, especially when it seems like everyone around them is having a good time.

But here's the thing: you have the right to make your own choices about what you do and don't do. And if you decide that you don't want to drink, that's okay. You don't have to justify it or explain it to anyone. You can simply say, "No, thank you," or "I'm not drinking tonight," and leave it at that.

It might also be helpful to remind yourself that your friends are likely to be more understanding than you think. They may even be impressed by your self-control and discipline. And if they're not, then that's okay too. You don't need to surround yourself with people who pressure you into doing things that don't feel right for you.

Another strategy might be to plan ahead and think about what you can do in social situations that doesn't involve drinking. For example, you could suggest doing something else with your friends, like going for a hike or playing a game. Or you could simply enjoy the company of your friends and engage in conversation without feeling like you need to drink to have a good time.

It's also important to remember that it's okay to take care of yourself and prioritize your own needs. If you're feeling like you're being pressured into drinking, it's okay to step away and take a break. You can say, "I need to take a break and get some fresh air," or "I'm going to go grab a water and catch up with you guys in a bit."

Remember, you're not alone in this. Many people struggle with the pressure to drink in social situations, and there are many resources available to support you. If you need some extra help or guidance, we can work on developing some strategies together.

How does that sound? Is there anything in particular that you'd like to work on or any specific situations that you'd like to prepare for?

**PATIENT (Turn 20)**

I think that makes sense. I just need to be more confident in my own choices and not worry so much about what others think. It's hard, but I can try to do that. Maybe I can even find some new friends who don't drink as much, or who are more supportive of my choices. That would be nice.

**THERAPIST (Turn 21)**

It's all about building confidence in your own choices and being true to yourself. And it's great that you're recognizing the importance of surrounding yourself with supportive people who respect your decisions.

Finding new friends who share similar values and interests can be a great way to build a supportive network. You might consider joining a club or group that aligns with your interests, volunteering for a cause you care about, or attending events that are geared towards people who share your values.

Remember, it's okay to take your time and to prioritize your own needs. You don't have to try to change everything at once. Just take small steps towards building a more supportive and healthy social network, and see where it takes you.

Also, keep in mind that it's not about avoiding people who drink or trying to change them. It's about finding people who respect your choices and support you in your goals. You can still have friends who drink, but it's about finding people who understand and respect your boundaries.

I want to leave you with a quote that I think is really relevant to this conversation: "You can't pour from an empty cup. Take care of yourself first." Remember that taking care of yourself and prioritizing your own needs is not selfish, it's necessary. You can't be the best version of yourself if you're not taking care of your own physical, emotional, and mental health.

I'm proud of you for taking the first steps towards making positive changes in your life. Keep in mind that it's a journey, and it's okay to take it one step at a time. You got this!